

Kentucky - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A volatile top-50 / lower-middle SEC team with enough line talent and defensive pieces to reach a bowl, but too much new staff, roster turnover and role uncertainty to project a clean Year 1 jump.
Preseason consensus	AP Unranked, zero votes · Conference poll SEC No. 14 (546 points, 1 first-place vote) · SP+ No. 47
Returning production	50% (No. 80) overall · Off. 47% (No. 94) · Def. 52% (No. 71)
Primer power rating	+4.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.5 wins · most likely 4-8 or 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Roughly similar overall, but with a wider range because the roster/staff reset could either unlock the offense or create a transition-year floor.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC Will Stein/OC Joe Sloan rebuild around QB Kenny Minchey, an open RB rotation and OL anchors OT Lance Heard/C Coleton Price. DC Jay Bateman installs an aggressive multiple-front 4-2-5, but WR/OL/secondary/edge roles remain unsettled.

Bottom line: Kentucky has quality line pieces and a coherent defensive reset, but low continuity, an unproven QB and SOS No. 7 make bowl eligibility an achievement rather than an assumption.

Beats expectations if: Minchey gives Sloan steady above-baseline quarterback play, Heard and Price anchor a quickly settled best five, at least two of the transfer/returning receivers emerge as dependable targets, and Bateman creates pressure without exposing the rebuilt secondary.

Disappoints if: The new offense remains as non-explosive as the 2025 unit, OL/WR rotations never settle, Afari remains unavailable and Greene's return is delayed, forcing a thin/rebuilt defense to face a top-heavy SEC schedule without enough offensive margin.

Five things to remember

- 1 Coaching:** The entire top staff is new: Will Stein is the head coach, Joe Sloan is the confirmed offensive play-caller, and Jay Bateman is the confirmed defensive play-caller.
- 2 ? QB question:** QB Kenny Minchey is the named starting quarterback, which removes the QB1 competition but not the performance uncertainty; that does not make him a proven high-level starter.
- 3 ? Defensive availability:** Offensive continuity is low (47% returning production, No.94): leading rusher RB Seth McGowan and leading receiver WR Kendrick Law were drafted, WR Hardley Gilmore IV was dismissed, and several material 2025 linemen also left for professional football or exhausted eligibility.
- 4 Defense:** Bateman's defense is designed to be fast and aggressive, but the active personnel picture is unstable: S Ty Bryant is the returning tackle anchor, Alex Afari Jr. is currently ineligible, Antonio O'Berry cannot play in 2026, and Sam Greene still needed final medical clearance.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The schedule offers little recovery time: SP+ SOS is No.7, Kentucky is projected for 4.5 wins, and the October sequence at South Carolina, LSU, at Oklahoma and Vanderbilt can determine whether the season still has a bowl path by the bye.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (2-6 SEC)	● Poor
Scoring	23.0 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	341.1 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	139.2 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	6.58 YPA · 15 TD / 14 INT	● Below average
Third downs	40.8%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	26.4 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	374.2 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	134.2 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	239.9 YPG · 8.04 YPA · 16 TD allowed	● Below average

The offense was a clear weakness, especially in scoring and passing efficiency. The defense was more competitive, with run defense notably better than pass efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+0.18 · No. 64	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.013 · No. 74	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	42.0% · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	9.7% · No. 127	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	17.5% · No. 113	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+1.80 · No. 49	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.034 · No. 50	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	45.2% · No. 118	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.9% · No. 67	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	14.9% · No. 82	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: The offense lacked explosiveness (No. 127) and allowed too much havoc (No. 113). The defense was respectable by adjusted/EPA ratings but poor at success-rate prevention and only average at creating havoc.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Will Stein - new external head coach from Oregon OC/QB role	● ↔ Stein brings a new offensive-led identity, with normal Year 1 staff and roster transition risk.
OC / offensive play-caller	◆ Joe Sloan - new external OC from LSU; is the 2026 offensive play-caller from the box	● ↔ Joe Sloan brings a new offensive system, but primary play-calling responsibility is already established.
DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Jay Bateman - new external DC from Texas A&M; is the defensive play-caller	● ↔ Jay Bateman brings a new defensive system with primary game-day play-calling responsibility established.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Kenny Minchey	Notre Dame	● ↔ Named starter and the central Year 1 variable.
◆ OT Lance Heard	Tennessee	● ↑ Clear tackle anchor with major preseason recognition.
◆ C Coleton Price	Baylor	● ↑ Veteran center anchor for an unsettled best five.
◆ RB CJ Baxter	Texas	● ↔ Major-role candidate in an open backfield that must replace 2025 leading rusher RB Seth McGowan.

Out	To	Loss
RB Seth McGowan	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 7, No. 237	● ↓ Leading rusher leaves a major workload vacancy.
WR Kendrick Law	NFL (Detroit), Round 5, No. 168	● ↓ Team-leading receiver leaves the largest target-volume hole.
WR Hardley Gilmore IV	Dismissed Aug. 6 for violation of team rules	● ↓ Removes another contributor from the rebuilt WR hierarchy.
OL Jalen Farmer	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 4, No. 113	● ↓ Material 2025 lineman and draft pick.
OL Jager Burton	NFL (Green Bay), Round 5, No. 153	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 lineman and draft pick.

Offensive net: Major composition reset with better-defined OL anchors but far less proven continuity at QB/RB/WR and across the remaining line.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DB Jordan Castell	Florida	● ↔ Major-role candidate who supplies experience to a rebuilt secondary but enters an unsettled final alignment.
◆ DB Aaron Gates	Florida	● ↔ Adds another starting/rotation candidate in the active secondary pool after multiple material departures.
◆ LB Tavion Wallace	Arkansas	● ↔ Competes for a major linebacker role in Bateman’s new 4-2-5 structure.
◆ DL Jamarrion Harkless	Purdue	● ↔ Major-front candidate who helps replace departures to professional football inside.

Out	To	Loss
LB Daveren Rayner	Undrafted; Atlanta NFL opportunity	● ↓ Sixty-nine tackles leave a meaningful LB hole.
CB JQ Hardaway	Rookie-minicamp opportunity (Tennessee Titans)	● ↓ Fifty-nine-tackle defensive back leaves.
DL David Gusta	CFL (BC Lions)	● ↓ Twelve-start 2025 defensive lineman departs, reducing front continuity.
S Jordan Lovett	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Starting safety loss increases the burden on S Ty Bryant.

Defensive net: A new pressure-oriented scheme has enough pieces to be functional, but high-volume/NFL losses plus Afari/O’Berry/Greene availability reduce continuity at every level.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	New Stein/Sloan offense around QB Kenny Minchey, RB-by-committee and OT Lance Heard/C Coleton Price.	Two OL anchors, TE Willie Rodriguez and multiple RB options.	No. 127 explosiveness plus major RB/WR/OL turnover.
Defense	DC Jay Bateman's aggressive multiple-front 4-2-5 uses pressure and man coverage.	S Ty Bryant plus transfer competition at all three levels.	No. 118 success-rate defense; DB Alex Afari Jr. ineligible and EDGE Sam Greene not yet cleared.
Special teams	Returning kicker stability paired with a reset punter job.	Jacob Kauwe returns after 13-of-17 field goals in 2025; Adam Zouagui adds competition/depth.	Aidan Laros left on an NFL path, no punter winner is established, and SP+ special teams is only No.75.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	QB Kenny Minchey is the named starter but remains unproven in the SEC.
RB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	RB CJ Baxter leads an open multi-back competition.
WR	● C	● ↓	Low	WR Nic Anderson joins a room replacing WR Kendrick Law and other production.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Willie Rodriguez is the clearest established receiving target.
OL	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	OT Lance Heard/C Coleton Price anchor an otherwise unsettled best five.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	DL Mi'Quise Humphrey-Grace anchors a front replacing major production.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium	LB Tavion Wallace enters after LB Daveren Rayner's departure.
Secondary	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	S Ty Bryant anchors a rebuilt group with DB Jordan Castell added.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	Jacob Kauwe returns after 13-of-17 field goals in 2025; Adam Zouagui adds competition/depth.
Coaching	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Entire top staff is new, though both coordinators have clear calling roles.
Overall	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	A volatile top-50 SEC team with enough line talent to bowl, but too much staff, roster and role turnover for a clean jump.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Kenny Minchey (TR: Notre Dame)	QB	● Named starter / swing player	-	Stein has already named him QB1; Kentucky's ability to escape its 2025 offensive ceiling starts with whether he can turn role certainty into efficient SEC quarterback play.
◆ Lance Heard (TR: Tennessee)	OT	● High-end line anchor	SEC Coaches 2nd team · SEC Media 2nd team · Outland	One of the few clearly established pieces in a rebuilt line and Kentucky's strongest recognition signal.
◆ Coleton Price (TR: Baylor)	C	● Veteran interior anchor	Rimington	Veteran center whose communication and stability matter disproportionately while the staff rotates multiple best-five combinations.
Willie Rodriguez	TE	● Established receiving tight end	SEC Coaches 3rd team · SEC Media 3rd team · John Mackey Award	Returns after 23 catches for 310 yards and provides the new quarterback/offense its clearest established pass-game role.
Ty Bryant	S	● Defensive volume anchor	-	Returns after a team-high 76 tackles and becomes the stabilizer in a secondary dealing with Hardaway/Lovett departures and Afari's ineligibility.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Mi'Quise Humphrey-Grace	DL	● Returning front anchor	-	Returns after 31 tackles and is one of the few continuity pieces in Bateman's fast/aggressive multiple front.
◆ CJ Baxter (TR: Texas)	RB	● Lead-role candidate	-	Texas transfer competing with RB Jovantae Barnes and Jason Patterson to replace McGowan's 2025 rushing production; the final split is deliberately unresolved.
◆ Jordan Castell (TR: Florida)	DB	● Major-role secondary transfer	-	Florida transfer enters the starting/major-role competition in a secondary that cannot currently count on Afari and lost multiple 2025 contributors.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Extremely difficult for a transition team; the SEC slate is loaded with top-30 SP+ opponents.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 7
Hardest stretch	at South Carolina → LSU → at Oklahoma → Vanderbilt
Swing games	Vanderbilt, Louisville, at South Carolina (upset-path swing if the new offense is ahead of baseline)
Advantage	The Oct. 31 bye precedes the closing run; Youngstown State and South Alabama provide the clearest relief.
Expected	4.5 wins · most likely 4-8 or 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	New-era optimism can outrun a SP+ No. 47, SEC No. 14 and 50% returning-production baseline against SOS No. 7.
Back them when	Getting points in lower-possession games where OT Lance Heard/C Coleton Price protect QB Kenny Minchey and the pressure package has matchup leverage.
Fade/pass when	Prices assume the portal reset fixed explosiveness, or opponents can isolate the unsettled secondary/edge group and force obvious passing downs.
Key monitor	Alex Afari Jr. eligibility/litigation status, Sam Greene final medical clearance, final OL five, WR target hierarchy, RB workload split
Week 1 baseline	vs. Youngstown State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Kentucky –23.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Kentucky's reset has a few reliable building blocks: QB Kenny Minchey is already named, OT Lance Heard/C Coleton Price anchor the line, and DC Jay Bateman has a clear aggressive plan. The challenge is turning those pieces into cohesion across an offense and defense with heavy turnover.

Availability concerns in the back seven and edge group add to the uncertainty, while SOS No. 7 leaves little recovery room. **4.5 wins and 4-8 or 5-7** is the proper baseline; a bowl would represent a successful Year 1 jump.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](#) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

© 2026 DRWhittier. Original analysis, commentary, selection, and arrangement.

Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#) · [current update 3](#) · [current update 4](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026